Writing Technique (Set B)

Year 4 · **Lesson Worksheet**

Worked Examples

Example 1 — Varying Openers: The dragon landed on the tower. Rewrite this sentence starting with a different word or phrase, without changing its meaning.

Answer: Landing on the tower, the dragon folded its wings. (Any new opener — e.g. an -ing clause, an adverb, or a prepositional phrase — that keeps the same meaning is correct.)

Example 2 — Show, Don't Tell: Turn this 'telling' sentence into a 'showing' one: 'The classroom was messy.'

Answer: Papers spilled off every desk and a chair lay on its side in the corner. (Accept any answer that shows the mess through concrete detail instead of naming it.)

Example 3 — Cohesion Between Sentences: Add a cohesive word or phrase to link these sentences smoothly: 'Leo forgot his homework. ___, he stayed in at lunchtime to finish it.'

Answer: Consequently / As a result / Therefore — any connective showing the lunchtime detention was a result of forgetting the homework.

Spotting the Technique (15 questions)

1. Which word in this sentence is the weakest, most overused verb? "The cat went across the garden and went up the tree." A) cat B) garden C) went D) tree E) across
2. "Slowly, the tortoise crossed the lawn." Name the type of sentence opener used here.
3. Which sentence below shows a character's boredom rather than telling us about it? A) Priya was extremely bored in the lesson. B) Priya felt bored. C) Priya yawned for the third time and doodled spirals in the margin of her book. D) Priya was not interested at all. E) Priya found the lesson boring.
4. Select ALL that apply: which of these are fronted adverbials (phrases placed at the start of a sentence, followed by a comma, describing when, where or how)? A) Without warning, the lights went out. B) The lights went out without warning. C) In the blink of an eye, the trick was over. D) He blinked. E) After the storm passed, the birds began to sing again.
5. Identify the cohesive device linking these two sentences: "Ahmed trained every single evening. Even so, he came last in the race."
6. Suggest one strong, precise verb to replace "said" in: "I'm not doing that," Ravi ___ angrily. A) said B) snapped C) spoke D) told E) mentioned
7. Which sentence uses a short sentence deliberately for dramatic impact after a longer build-up? A) "The corridor stretched on, dim and silent, every door shut tight. Then: a scream." B) "The corridor was long and I walked down it." C) "It was a corridor, and it was quiet, and nothing happened." D) "The corridor, which was long, was also quiet, and also dark." E) "There was a corridor and it was dark and long and silent and empty."
8. "Huge" and "nice" are examples of which kind of word writers are usually told to avoid overusing?
9. Which opener below is a prepositional phrase opener? A) Quietly, she tiptoed past. B) Beneath the floorboards, something scratched. C) Tiptoeing past, she held her breath. D) She tiptoed past quietly. E) Because it was late, she tiptoed past.

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10. Select ALL that apply: which of these sentences "tell" an emotion rather than "show" it? A) Omar was furious. B) Omar's fists clenched and his jaw tightened. C) Omar felt extremely angry indeed. D) Omar slammed the door so hard the glass rattled. E) Omar was an angry boy that day.

11. In the pair "The fire alarm rang. Meanwhile, the fire drill had already begun outside." — what does the word "Meanwhile" tell the reader? A) cause and effect B) that two things are happening at the same time C) a contrast D) a result E) a conclusion

12. Replace the weak adjective "big" in "It was a big dog" with a more precise alternative that suggests the dog was intimidating.

13. Which technique is being used here: "She knocked. Silence. She knocked again."?

14. Identify the fronted adverbial in: "Against all odds, the smallest runner crossed the line first."

15. Select ALL that apply: which of these words/phrases can act as cohesive devices linking ideas ACROSS paragraphs? A) In addition to this, ... B) banana C) Having considered the arguments above, ... D) purple E) On the other hand, ...

Applying the Technique (15 questions)

1. Rewrite this sentence so it opens with an -ing clause instead of "The": "The thief crept along the corridor, checking every door."

2. Combine these two short sentences into one, using a subordinating connective to build a sense of anticipation: "The sky darkened. The first drops of rain fell."

3. Rewrite "Mia was excited." using show, don't tell (do not use the word "excited" or "happy").

4. Choose the set of replacements that makes this sentence strongest: "The nice man walked to the big house and said hello." A) kind, strolled, enormous, whispered B) nice, walked, big, said (unchanged) C) good, moved, large, spoke D) pleasant, went, huge, told E) friendly, ambled, towering, called

5. Add a cohesive phrase to link these sentences, showing a contrast: "The forecast promised sunshine all day. ___, by noon the clouds had rolled in."

6. Write a short, dramatic sentence followed by a longer explanatory one about this event: "The power went out."

7. Select ALL that apply: which rewrites below successfully vary the sentence opener away from a repeated "He"? A) He walked in and he sat down and he sighed. B) Walking in, he sat down and sighed. C) With a heavy sigh, he walked in and sat down. D) He, walking in, sat and sighed heavily. E) Sighing heavily, he walked in and sat down.

8. Rewrite "The storm was scary." as a showing sentence using at least one sensory detail (sound, sight, touch, smell or taste).

9. Which connecting word best links these ideas to show a result? "Jamal revised every topic on the list. ___, he felt confident walking into the exam." A) However B) Meanwhile C) Therefore D) Although E) Otherwise

10. Rewrite this flat sentence using a stronger verb and a fronted adverbial: "The boy went down the hill on his bike quickly."

11. Combine these three short, choppy sentences into one well-structured sentence, varying length for effect if you wish: "The crowd was silent. The whistle blew. The race began."

12. Identify and correct the weak adjective choice in this sentence, replacing it with something more precise: "The food tasted bad."

13. Add a cohesive device at the start of the second part to link it back to the first: "...and the expedition set off at dawn. ___, by midday the heat had become unbearable."

14. Select ALL that apply: which of these sentence openers would help vary a paragraph that currently starts every sentence with a name (e.g. "Zara...Zara...Zara...")? A) Starting with a pronoun instead, e.g. "She..." B) Repeating

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the name again for clarity. C) Starting with a fronted adverbial, e.g. "Without hesitation, Zara..." D) Starting with an -ing clause, e.g. "Hesitating, Zara..." E) Always starting with "And then Zara..."

15. Rewrite "It was dark and I was scared." as two sentences: one long sentence building atmosphere, then one very short sentence for impact.

Technique in Context (15 questions)

1. Read: "The door creaked open. Then, silence." Explain the effect created by the final short sentence "Then, silence."

2. This sentence overuses 'and': "She opened her bag and she took out her book and she started reading." Rewrite it with varied sentence openers.

3. Which sentence combines a fronted adverbial AND a strong verb? A) Without warning, the train screeched to a halt. B) The train stopped. C) The train, which stopped, did so suddenly. D) Suddenly the train stopped.

4. Explain why "The silence was loud." is a 'telling' sentence, then rewrite it as a 'showing' sentence.

5. Identify the cohesive device in this pair of sentences and explain its function: "Leo trained for weeks. Nevertheless, he still felt nervous on the day."

6. Select ALL that apply: which of these avoid repeating the same weak word too often? A) Using 'nice', 'big' and 'good' repeatedly. B) Replacing 'nice' with more precise words each time. C) Varying sentence openers instead of always starting with 'The'. D) Starting every sentence with 'The storm...'

7. A student writes three short sentences: "I was nervous. I was scared. I felt worried." Rewrite this as one effective sentence.

8. Which sentence opens with an -ing clause? A) Gripping the rail tightly, Mia looked down. B) Mia looked down, gripping the rail. C) Mia gripped the rail and looked down. D) Mia was looking down.

9. Rewrite this run-on sentence using two shorter, clearer sentences: "The bell rang and everyone ran for the door and some pushed."

10. Explain, in your own words, why writers use 'show, don't tell' instead of simply naming a character's feeling.

11. Select ALL that apply: which of these are strong, precise verbs rather than weak, vague ones? A) 'scurried' instead of 'went' B) 'got' instead of 'received' C) 'whispered' instead of 'said' D) 'did' instead of 'performed'

12. A paragraph starts every sentence with 'Then'. Suggest two different ways the writer could open a sentence instead, giving one example of each.

13. Identify the technique used here and explain its effect: "Hope flickered, then faded, inside her."

14. Which connective best links these ideas to show contrast? "Sam trained for months. ___, he still lost the race." A) Therefore B) However C) Similarly D) Meanwhile

15. Rewrite "It was dark and I was scared." as two sentences: one longer sentence building atmosphere, then one short sentence for impact.

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